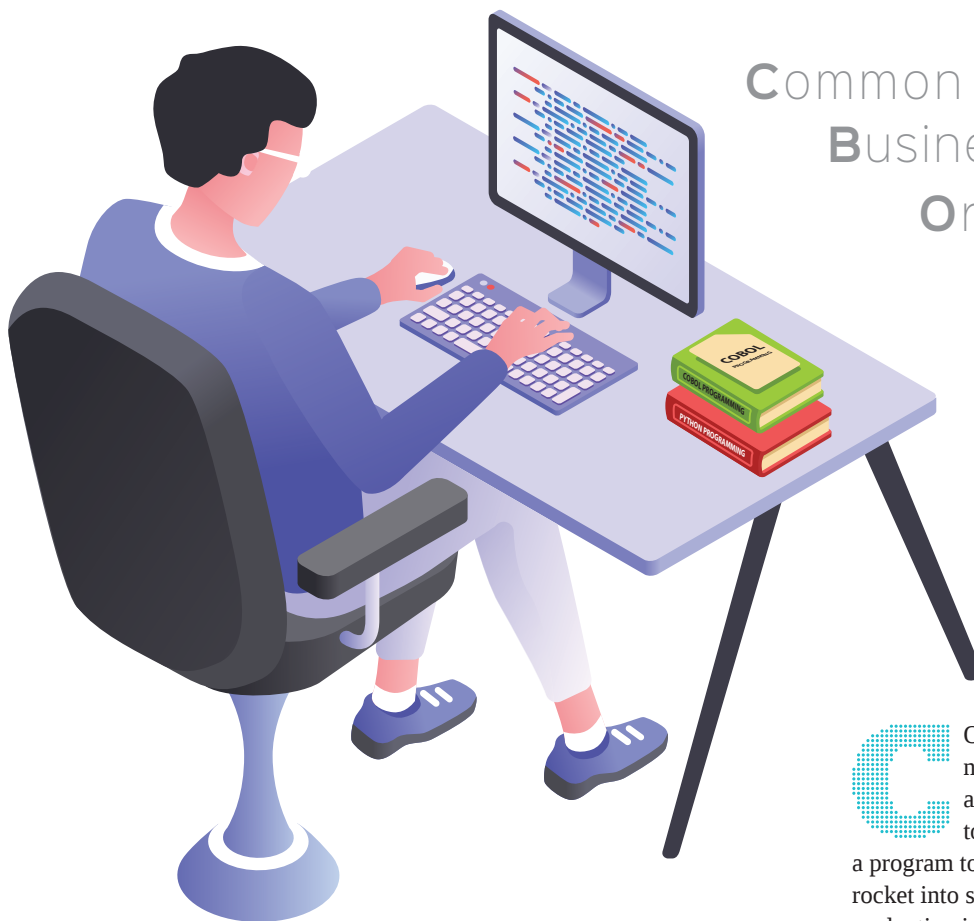


Classical Programming Languages: The Legacy of COBOL



Common
Business
Oriented
Language
COBOL

COBOL is still relevant for a number of reasons. First, it is a simple language and easy to learn. If you need to write a program to control the launch of a rocket into space, you will definitely be evaluating integrals, Fourier transforms and a whole lot of other difficult mathematical functions. COBOL is not suitable for such applications. But if your sole aim is to perform a simple task like payroll management, for which all that is needed are basic arithmetic operations, then the use of COBOL is justified. You don't need a cannon to kill a fly. But if merely being simple or easy to learn was the sole advantage of COBOL, then it would have definitely died out a long time ago.

The first article in this series defined the term classical programming languages. The longevity of three programming languages, Fortran, COBOL and Pascal (more than five decades) is the reason for calling them classical programming languages. COBOL is an acronym for Common Business-Oriented Language, which is almost exclusively used for programming business applications. Let's find out why it is relevant even today.